



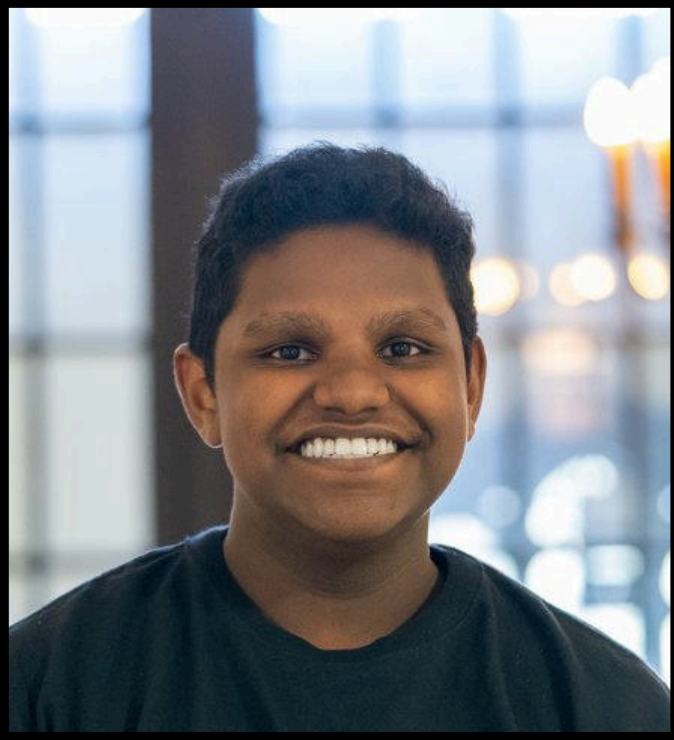
THE GIRL UNDER THE RAMBUTAN TREE



Written By:
Nadith Ranasinghe

Illustrations By:
Danielle Xin and
Dilnazz Matharu

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Nadith Ranasinghe

Nadith Ranasinghe is the founder & president of Kids Health Shelf (KHS), an organization dedicated to sharing stories of diversity and inclusion – by university students for the youth of tomorrow.

He is a Physiology student at the University of Western Ontario, and apart from writing, enjoys playing badminton and watching Sci-Fi movies with his friends.

THE KHS TEAM

Founder & President: Nadith Ranasinghe

VP Finances: Adam Taylor

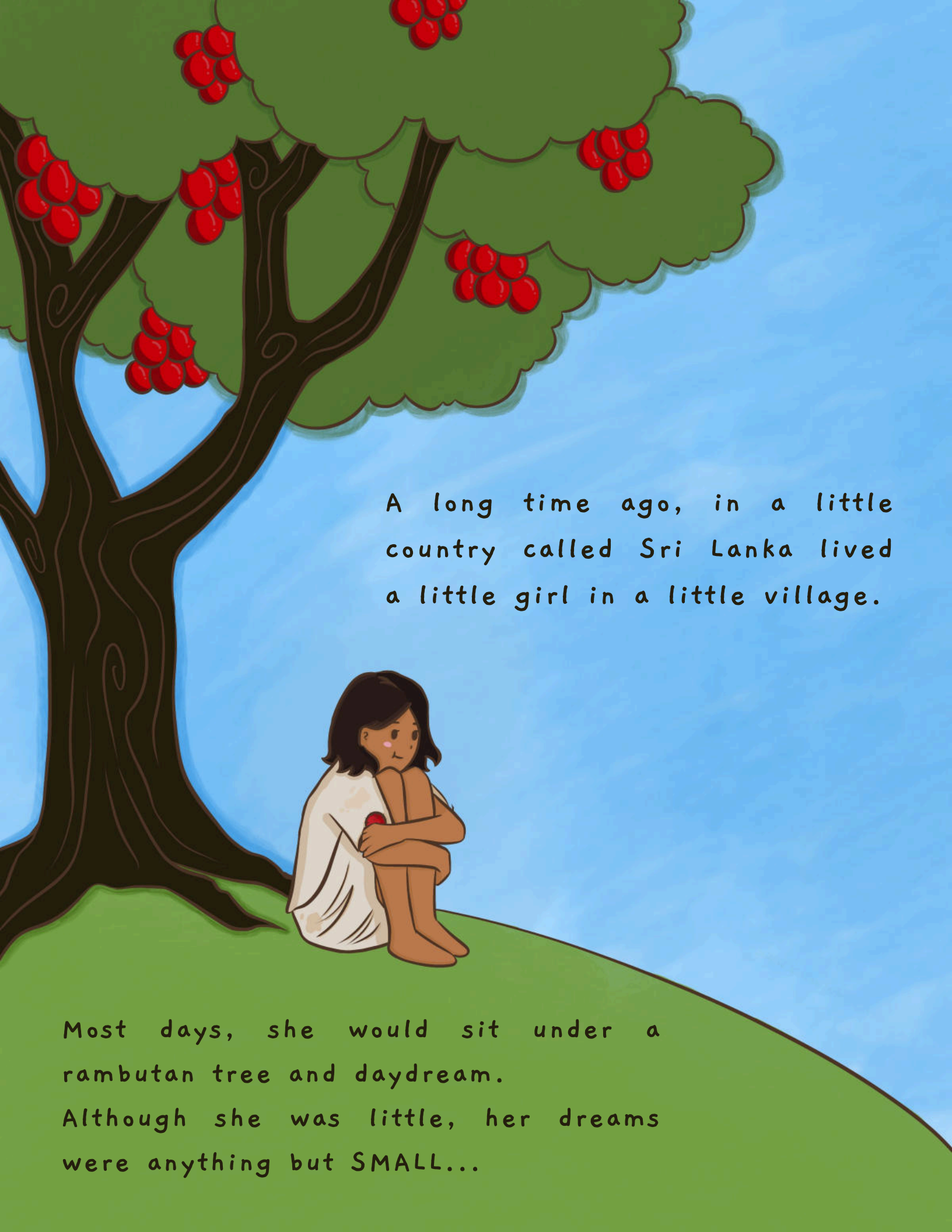
VP Promotions: Estella Pham

VP Illustration: Danielle Xin & Amy Shi

VP Authorship: Emily Leha & Lisa Zhu

Volunteer Illustrators: Dilnazz Mathru & Sophie Smith

Brand Strategist & Website Director: Gurkirat (Ronnie) Kainth



A long time ago, in a little
country called Sri Lanka lived
a little girl in a little village.

Most days, she would sit under a
rambutan tree and daydream.
Although she was little, her dreams
were anything but SMALL...



In school she loved to learn and play to her fullest and was always the first, whether it came to answering a class question...

...or hitting a serve on her school volleyball team.



No matter what, she always made sure to try her absolute BEST!

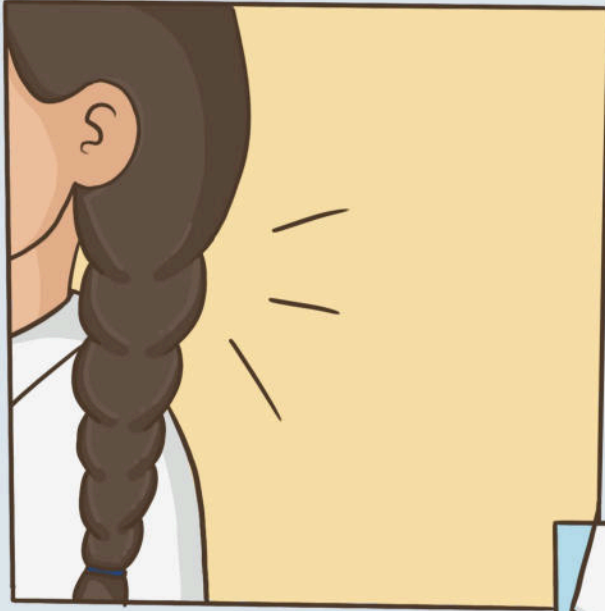
Her passion always found her at the end of awards and podiums, where she would be adorned with different coloured medals and gifted with various trophies. These prizes were nice to have, but she always found that something was looming over her head.



Growing up, she didn't have much money. Both of her parents were labourers, who would work long hours into the night to give her a chance at a better life. From the outside, she seemed to be as happy as anyone else, but on the inside, she found it impossible to fit in.



Every day in school, she would see her classmates...



...with their newly
pampered hair...

...and neatly
pressed
uniforms...

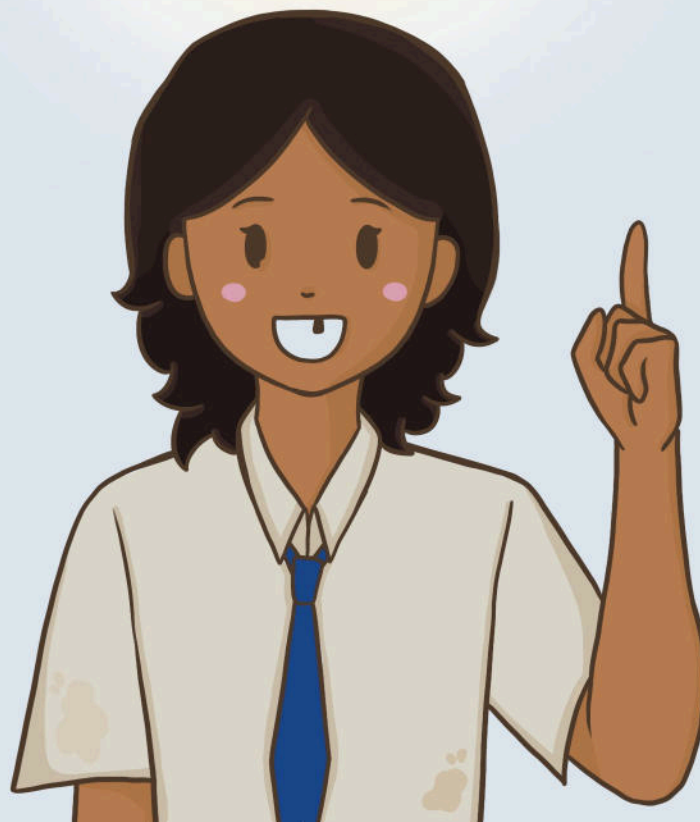


...eating their
smoothly spread
buttered toast.



Not being able to afford any of these things,
she would often keep to herself...

...until one day when she had a
GENIUS idea!





She decided that if she couldn't buy what she wanted, she would make it herself.

She spent hours sewing her own uniform, thread by thread, working late into the night.



She even tried her best to straighten her curly hair...



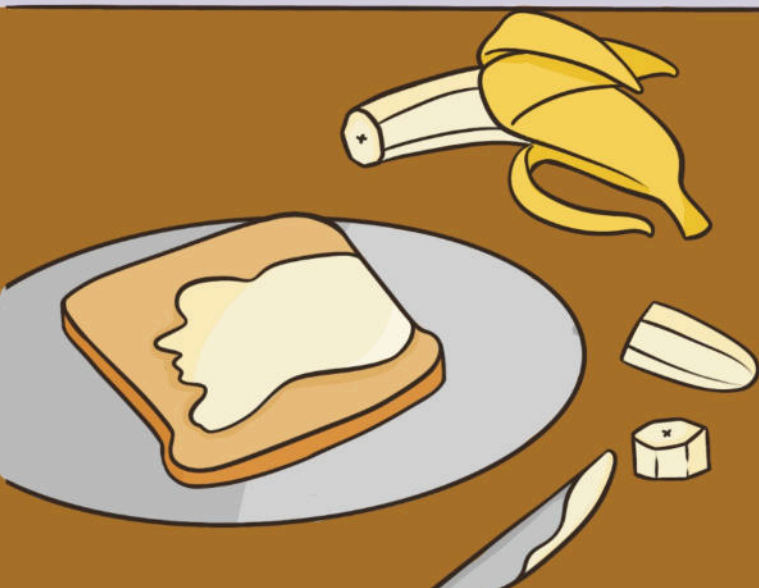
but it never ended up looking the best...



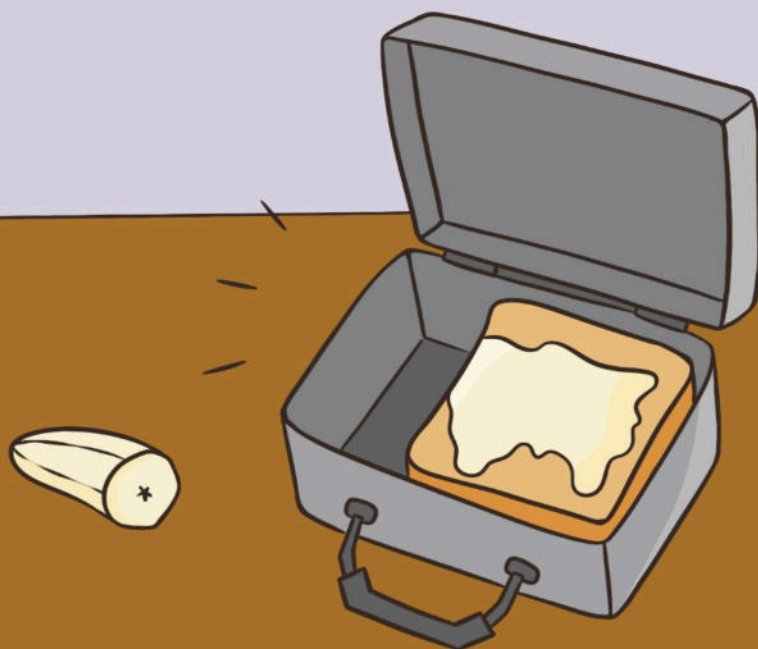
Having “fixed” her clothes and hair, all she needed now was some buttered toast. Not having anything to replace butter, she goes with the next best thing...bananas!



After picking some ripe bananas from the tree, she spread them on a piece of bread to make it look like butter.



In her own special way, she made herself...Banana Bread!



The next morning, she eagerly gets up and runs to school, excited to show her class her new apparel. She walks into class happily imagining all the new friends she'll finally have, but as she approaches them, she feels anything but acceptance.



Seeing her messy dress and tangled hair, she looked around nervously as her classmates teased her.

Her once shimmering smile slowly started to fade away...





With her heart heavy, she ran back home with tears in her eyes. Even after trying her very best, and giving it her all, she still couldn't make new friends.



She sat on the porch, feeling the lowest she had ever felt.

Her parents, coming home and seeing their daughter, hugged her tightly - their warmth comforting her tears. While they might not have been able to give her money from their pockets, they showered her with love from their hearts.



“Sweetheart,” her mom whispered,
“True friends will love you for who you
are inside, not how you look outside.

Changing yourself won't make you
happy, but if you stay true to who you
are, the best of friends will be sure to
come.”



With those sentimental words, the little girl learned a very valuable lesson. She decided that she shouldn't change for the world, but the world should learn to accept her for who she was.



From that day on, if she ever heard her classmates laughing or snickering at her...



...she would join in, and laugh alongside them!



Finding confidence in herself, and not letting other students bring her down, she put even more effort into school and eventually...



...she achieved her dream of becoming a
doctor - finding happiness and friends that
accepted her for who she was!



Many years later, after this
young girl had children of her
own...



...Her son proudly
hung up her picture
in their little house.



While many might call
her brave, inspirational,
or a role model...



...I'm lucky enough to
call her Amma



The End

ABOUT THE ILLUSTRATORS



Danielle Xin

Danielle is one of the VPs of Illustration for KHS. Although she has a background in science, she has always had a creative side and hopes to combine her love for both art and science! Through her illustrations, she is dedicated to creating inspiring content that will educate young minds on the importance of diversity and inclusion in healthcare.

Dilnazz Matharu is a dedicated Health Sciences student with a passion for exploring the social determinants of health and advancing health equity. As an illustrator for this book, she seeks to inspire children to stay true to themselves and pursue their dreams with unwavering determination.



Dilnazz Matharu

ABOUT THE BOOK



Nadith Ranasinghe (left) wrote this book as a touching tribute to his mother Deepika Perera (right) and her struggles growing up in rural Sri Lanka.

The story is a reflection of the reality that many Sri Lankan children, and children across developing nations overall, continue to go through daily. This book serves to increase awareness of children like Deepika - and provide opportunities for them to succeed in their endeavours.



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